Papers in Informatics, Paper 9, December 2001, ISSN 1400-7428

# Mobile Newsmaking

**Kerstin Forsberg**

Department of Informatics,
Göteborg University, Sweden

kerstin.forsberg@viktoria.se, www.informatics.gu.se

Licentiate Thesis

## Abstract

The research reported in this thesis concerns the design of new and innovative IT support for mobile news journalism. News journalists often have to report events on topics that they do not know very well and with little time for preparation. News reporting is often conducted in the field, away from the stationary IT support.

The scope of this research is limited to the early phase of newsmaking when journalists transform everyday occurrences and happenings into newsworthy stories, discuss news events and formulate news tasks, do background research and frame news stories. The research question addressed is: *How to provide reporters with contextual information relevant for news tasks in mobile situations?* Contextual information reminds the reporter of the context for the task at hand. Helps the reporter to ask relevant and interesting questions and to properly frame the news story.

The thesis contains field studies, design implications and applications of mobile technologies. The following theoretical and practical results are described: 1) NewsSpace, a design model describing new ways of using IT in news journalism, 2) NewsMate, a prototype of an IT service for mobile reporters, 3) FieldWise, a generalised architecture for mobile knowledge management, 4) A description of the newsmaking process focusing on the early phase of articulation and contextualisation of news tasks, and 5) A news task structure, called Localising News, and proposals of how the utilisation of task structures could improve the IT support for mobile news journalism.



**Keywords**

Informatics, Mobile CSCW, Journalism, Ethnography, Empirically informed systems design, Handheld devices

**Language**

English

Papers in Informatics, Paper 9, December 2001,
ISSN 1400-7428

No. of pages 101

# Preface

The thesis is a collection of four papers and an introduction. This forms the result of a collaboration effort between academia and industry that started in 1997 when the Viktoria institute was established and a Ph.D. programme for people in industry was launched. The work reported in the thesis has been done as part of the Mobile Informatics programme. Mobile Informatics is an applied research area exploring and realising new and innovative IT services for the "nomadic networker" of the future.

The overall task for the research is the *design of new and innovative IT services supporting mobile news journalism*. The specific research question is: *How to provide reporters with contextual information for news tasks in mobile situations?*

## Sponsor Acknowledgements

The Swedish Research Institute for Information Technology (SITI) grants for the Mobile Informatics programme has funded the MobiNews project.

## Acknowledgements

There are four groups of people who in their special way have contributed to the completion of my thesis. Firstly, research supervisors and colleagues, secondly, my professional mentors, fellow workers and employers, thirdly, speaking partners in several Swedish news organisations, and fourthly, my family. Please forgive me if I have forgotten to mention any of you.

I am very happy that I have had the opportunity to join the research network that Professor Bo Dahlbom has established at the Viktoria Institute. I am deeply grateful to my supervisors Fredrik Ljungberg and Urban Nuldén. Both of them have inspired and

supported me through the last four years. A special thank you goes to Henrik Fagrell, my friend and research colleague in the MobiNews project. To my other co-authors – Johan Sanneblad, Ingela Bruce, Martin Börjesson, Erik Johannesson and Erika Wollerfjord – many thanks. I would also like to thank other colleagues in the Viktoria community, especially the members of the Mobile Informatics group.

I am grateful to Christian Forsäng at Volvo IT, who recruited me in the first place to this exiting adventure in the borderline between academia and industry. A special thanks goes to my fellow industrial Ph.D. colleagues. Also, thanks to Lars Dannstedt, one of my co-author, and to other friends and previous co-workers at Volvo IT.

During the last four years combining work and research, I have been working in different organisations. Most of the time I have been employed at Astrakan Strategic Development. I have been encouraged by two of the founders of Astrakan: Clas-Göran Lövetoft and Jonas Leffler. Clas-Göran has been my mentor as being an explorer himself. Jonas has been my supporter as also being a part time researcher.

During almost one year I had the pleasure of working together with Mikael Stenhamn, Bernt Rane, Andreas Hallberg, Patrick Olnäs, Martin Fredriksson, Calin Gherman, Cem Yeter, Jonas Ström and Frederik Kämmerer. Our start-up company, Instant Context Technologies, did not succeed in commercialising the research results, but we learned a lot. My new employer, AstraZeneca, and in particular Peter Bares, has made it possible for me to conclude this thesis.

I wish to express my sincere gratitude to Anders Aare, Per Andersson-Ek, Tomas Bibin, Mia Bjelkholm, Bengt Engwall, Louise Hamilton, Niklas Jonasson, Urban Jörnér, Thorbjörn Lindskog, Charlotta Medin, Stig Nordqvist, Sven Ringmar, Staffan Sandberg and Henrik Tengby for interesting discussions about new ways of using information technology in news and newsmaking.

Finally, above all, I would like to thank my beloved family, Björn and Erik. Together with Eva, Alexandra, Anne-Marie and Rune, you have supported and encouraged me. You have definitely been the ones who have made it possible for me to accomplish this task.

Kerstin Forsberg, Göteborg, November 2001.

# Contents

**Introduction – Mobile Newsmaking** **1**

**Navigating in NewsSpace** **27**

**NewsMate: Providing Timely Information to Mobile and Distributed News Journalists** **49**

**Fieldwise: a Mobile Knowledge Management Architecture** **55**

**Localising News: Task Articulation and Contextualisation in Mobile News Journalism** **79**

**Note:** a digital version of the thesis is available at http://www.viktoria.se/~kerstinf/thesis/ This web page also includes errata and links to additional material.